

EXTRACURRICULARS THAT ACTUALLY IMPRESS COLLEGES

a guide for high school juniors by @fatimahs.guide

1. START A MICRO BUSINESS SOLVING A REAL PROBLEM

Colleges love entrepreneurial initiative because it shows leadership, problem-solving, and real-world impact.

Examples:

- Tutoring service: Teach middle schoolers coding, math, or SAT prep
- Social media management: Help local businesses with their Instagram or TikTok
- Lawn care or pet sitting: Classic neighborhood services with real income
- Reselling or Etsy shop: Thrift flipping, handmade jewelry, digital downloads
- Web design for small businesses: Build simple sites using free tools
- Event planning: Organize birthday parties or community events
- Content creation: Start a YouTube channel or blog teaching something you know

2. CREATE A COMMUNITY ADVOCACY PROJECT

Find an issue in your local area and actually do something about it.

Examples:

- Food insecurity campaign: Organize food drives or start a school pantry
- Environmental initiative: Beach cleanups, tree planting, petition for recycling programs
- Mental health awareness: Create a peer support group or organize wellness workshops
- Voter registration drives: Help eligible students register to vote
- STEM access for underrepresented students: Teach coding to younger kids
- Present to city council: Research a local issue and formally propose solutions
- Period poverty project: Collect and distribute menstrual products to schools or shelters
- Senior citizen tech help: Teach older adults how to use smartphones or video calls

3. BECOME A CERTIFIED EXPERT IN SOMETHING UNIQUE

Certifications aren't just resume fillers—they're proof of real skills.

Examples:

- CPR/First Aid certified (Red Cross)
- Lifeguard certification
- Google certifications (data analytics, project management, digital marketing)
- Coding certifications (freeCodeCamp, Coursera, HarvardX CS50)
- Language proficiency (DELE for Spanish, HSK for Chinese, JLPT for Japanese)
- Adobe Certified Professional (Photoshop, Lightroom)
- EMT certification (check age requirements in your state)
- Referee or umpire certification for sports you play
- Food handler's permit

REMEMBER: Colleges value DEPTH over breadth. Pick a few of these and go all in rather than doing 10 things halfway. Show progression, leadership, and measurable impact.